

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

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To the Bahá'ís of the World

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1 August 2014

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Dearly loved Friends,

32.1 Over two years have elapsed since our announcement at Rid.ván 2012 of projects to raise two national and five local Houses of Worship, to be pursued in conjunction with the construction in Santiago, Chile, of the last of the continental Mashriqu'l-Adhkárs. These undertakings, inextricably linked to the development of community life now being fostered every-where through acts of devotion and service, are further steps in the sublime task entrusted to humanity by Bahá'u'lláh to build Houses of Worship “throughout the lands in the name of Him Who is the Lord of all religions”—centers in which souls may gather “harmoniously attuned one to another” to hear the divine verses and to offer supplications, and from which “the voices of praise may rise to the Kingdom” and the “fragrance of God” be diffused.

32.2 We are deeply moved by the response in every part of the world to our call. Particularly in the nations and localities recently designated for the construction of a House of Worship, we have witnessed the friends' spontaneous expressions of

joy; their immediate and heartfelt commitment to lend their share in carrying out the critical work at hand and to increase the dynamism of those activities integral to the emergence of a Mashriqu'l-Adhkár within a population; their sacrificial contributions of time, energy, and material resources, in a variety of forms; and their sustained efforts to awaken growing contingents to the vision of those edifices dedicated wholly to the remembrance of God that will be founded in their midst. Indeed, the ready response of the community of the Greatest Name augurs well for its ability to further these collective undertakings.

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FRAMEWORK FOR ACTION32.3 The National Spiritual Assemblies of the Democratic Republic of the Congo and Papua New Guinea as well as those of Cambodia, Colombia, India, Kenya, and Vanuatu, with the close support of the Office of Temples and Sites created at the Bahá'í World Centre in 2012, promptly moved forward with the initial preparations. A committee was formed in each country, entrusted with identifying, together with institutions and agencies at all levels of the community, means to promote wide-spread participation and to channel the enthusiasm engendered among the friends following the announcement of the projects. Another practical step in these national and local projects has been the selection of a suitable piece of land, one which is modest in size, strategically located, and easily accessible.

Four of the seven properties are now in hand. A construction office for each project is being established to assist with the management of technical, financial, and legal issues. The work involved in the opening stage has advanced through generous contributions from the friends all over the world to the Temples Fund. Universal and sacrificial support for this Fund will ensure the steady progress of the next phases.

32.4 In four countries, the projects have reached the stage of preparing a design for the Temple edifice. This begins with the selection of potential architects and the formulation of an ar -

chitectural brief defining the requirements for the structure, and it ultimately results in a contract for the final design. Architects

are presented with the singular challenge of designing Temples “as perfect as is possible in the world of being” that harmonize

naturally with the local culture and the daily lives of those

who will gather to pray and meditate therein. The task calls for creativity and skill to combine beauty, grace, and dignity with

modesty, functionality, and economy. A number of architects

from near and far have gladly offered their services, and

while such contributions are of course welcomed, National

Assemblies are giving due regard to the value of engaging architects who are well acquainted with the area where the

edifice will be built.

32.5 The erection of the continental House of Worship for

South America is moving towards its completion in Chile. The steel-frame superstructure has been almost entirely installed, the

placement of the interior translucent stone panels is under way,

and the landscaping and the construction of auxiliary facilities

are progressing according to schedule. The friends in Santiago,

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diligently striving to prepare the surrounding population for

the emergence of the House of Worship; increasing numbers

are participating in the community-building endeavors, and a

stream of visitors are being welcomed to the Temple site for

prayer and discussion on the practical and spiritual dimensions of the enterprise. Measures are currently being put in place in

that country in anticipation of the many demands that are sure

to arise once the Temple is inaugurated in 2016.

32.6 As the friends worldwide rejoice in these heartening ad-

vances, their energies remain focused on the processes gaining

strength in cluster after cluster. In this, they have not failed

to appreciate the dynamic interaction between worship and en-

deavors to uplift the spiritual, social, and material conditions of

society. May all those who are thus laboring in towns and cities, neighborhoods and villages, derive insights from the exertions

made to raise up the first two Houses of Worship at the turn of the twentieth century, in the East and then in the West.

32.7 In the city of 'Ishqábád, a devoted band of believers who settled from Persia, and who, for a time, found peace and tranquillity in Turkistán, bent their energies towards the creation of a pattern of life that would reflect the exalted spiritual and social principles enshrined in the Revelation of Bahá'u'lláh. In a span of a few decades, this group, originally consisting of a handful of families, was joined there by others and grew to a few thousand believers. This community, fortified by ties of camaraderie and animated by unity of purpose and a spirit of faithfulness, was enabled to reach a high degree of cohesiveness and development, for which it gained renown throughout the Bahá'í world. These friends, guided by their understanding of the divine Teachings, and within the bounds of the religious freedom they were accorded, toiled to create the conditions that would lead to the founding of a Mashriqu'l-Adhkár, that "crowning institution in every Bahá'í community." On a befitting tract of land in the center of the city that had been obtained some years before with the consent of the Blessed Beauty

Himself, facilities were built for communal well-being—a meeting hall, schools for children, a hostel for visitors, and a small clinic, among others. A sign of the notable achievements of the

Bahá'ís in 'Ishqábád, who in those productive years became distinguished for their prosperity, magnanimity, and intellectual

and cultural attainments, was their attention to ensuring that

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FRAMEWORK FOR ACTION All Bahá'í children and youth were literate in a society with rampant illiteracy, especially among girls. Within such an environment of unified endeavor and progress, and fostered at every stage of development by 'Abdu'l-Bahá, a magnificent House of Worship emerged—the most prominent edifice in the area. For over twenty years, the friends experienced the heavenly joy of having realized their lofty aim: the establishment of a focal

point of worship, a nerve center of community life, a place

where souls gathered at daybreak for humble invocation and communion before flowing out of its doors to engage in their daily pursuits. While the forces of irreligion eventually swept through the region and thwarted hopes, the brief appearance of a Mashriqu'l-Adhkár in 'Ishqábád is an enduring testament to the volition and effort of a body of believers who established a rich pattern of life deriving its impetus from the power of the Creative Word.

32.8 In the Western Hemisphere, shortly after work commenced on the House of Worship in 'Ishqábád, the members of the nascent Bahá'í community in North America were galvanized to demonstrate their faith and devotion by constructing a Temple of their own, and they wrote in 1903 to seek the Master's consent. From that moment, the Mashriqu'l-Adhkár became inseparably intertwined with the fate of those dedicated servants of Bahá'u'lláh. While progress on this complex project was obstructed over decades by the effects of two world wars and a widespread economic depression, each stage in its development was intimately tied to the expansion of the community and the unfoldment of its administration. On the same day as the interment of the sacred remains of the Báb on Mount Carmel in March 1909, delegates gathered to establish the Bahá'í Temple Unity, a national organization whose elected Board became the nucleus of the far-flung local communities of the continent. This development soon gave rise to the formation of the National Spiritual Assembly of the Bahá'ís of the United States and Canada. 'Abdu'l-Bahá Himself laid the cornerstone of the building during His travels to North America, endowing the Mother Temple of the West with tremendous spiritual potentialities. And contributions for this historic enterprise flowed from Bahá'í centers in Africa, Asia, Europe, Latin America, and the Pacific—a demonstration of the solidarity and sacrifice of the Bahá'ís of the East and West.

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thoughts on God and occupy themselves each day with His remembrance, ceaselessly exerting effort in His Name, let

them draw inspiration from these stirring words addressed by
 ‘Abdu’l-Bahá to a believer who was devoted to building the first
 House of Worship, raised under His close and loving direction:
 32.10 Hasten now to ‘Ishqábád, in the utmost detachment and aflame with the fire of
 attraction, and convey to the friends
 of God ardent greetings from ‘Abdu’l-Bahá. Kiss thou each
 one’s face and express this servant’s deep and sincere af-
 fection to all. Do thou on behalf of ‘Abdu’l-Bahá move the
 earth, carry the mortar, and haul the stones for the building of the Mashriqu’l-Adhkár so that
 the rapture of this service
 may bring joy and gladness to the Center of Servitude. That
 Mashriqu’l-Adhkár is the first visible and manifest estab-lishment of the Lord. Therefore, it
 is this servant’s hope that
 each and every virtuous and righteous soul will sacrifice
 his all, evince great happiness and exultation, and rejoice
 in carrying the earth and mortar so that this Divine Edifice
 may be raised, the Cause of God may spread, and in every corner of the world the friends
 may arise with the utmost
 resolve to accomplish this great task. Were ‘Abdu’l-Bahá
 not imprisoned and were there not obstacles in his path, he himself would assuredly hasten
 to ‘Ishqábád and carry the
 earth for the building of the Mashriqu’l-Adhkár with the
 utmost joy and gladness. It behoveth the friends now to
 arise with this intention in mind and serve in my place so
 that in a short time this Edifice may be revealed to all eyes, the loved ones of God may
 engage in making mention of the
 Abhá Beauty, the melodies of the Mashriqu’l-Adhkár may
 rise at dawning to the Concourse on high, and the songs
 of the nightingales of God may bring joy and ecstasy to
 the denizens of the All-Glorious Realm. Thus will the hearts rejoice, the souls delight in
 joyful tidings, and the minds be
 illumined. This is the highest hope of the sincere ones; this
 is the dearest wish of them that are nigh unto God.

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]